Doctoral Program (PhD) in Biomedical Sciences

Global Health track

Academic Policies, Guidelines and Procedures

HANDBOOK

September 2023

UNIVERSITÉ DE GENÈVE
FACULTY OF MEDICINE
Institute of Global Health

These *Guidelines and Procedures* describe rules, policies, and procedures for the Doctoral Program in Biomedical Sciences, track « Global Health » (PhD), as established by the Medical Faculty of Geneva and in accordance with the regulations of the Swiss School of Public Health (SSPH+).

Each student should become familiar with the material pertaining to this program, and together with a faculty advisor, make certain that the selected plan of study complies with the relevant requirements.

Foreword

The Institute of Global Health, Faculty of Medicine, University of Geneva in collaboration with the Swiss School of Public Health presents the first PhD track in global health created as a partly online distance program.

Formally known as the Institute of Social and Preventive Medicine, the Institute of Global Health was founded by Prof. Antoine Flahault in January 2014. Under his directorship, this innovative doctoral program was created in response to the urgent need for developing implementation research in the field of public and global health, using a transdisciplinary approach. Starting in 2023, the PhD in global health program is directed by Prof. Nicolas Ray who is bringing his expertise in transdisciplinary research and implementation in low- and middle-income countries.

The primary goal of the PhD in global health program is to train students to be able to bridge existing gaps between practical knowledge and academic and research skills in the field of global health. The PhD program combines both onsite and distance learning approaches, allowing candidates to work in their respective countries while pursuing their thesis.

The PhD program in Global Health is anchored in Geneva, a globally recognized hub for health and humanitarian initiatives, offering students a unique ecosystem in which to learn and grow. The presence of major international health organizations, such as the World Health Organization, the Red Cross, and numerous non-governmental organizations, enables students to gain insights directly from world leaders in global health.

We hope this handbook will give you all necessary pieces of information to ease your journey through the unique opportunities, challenges, and joy that a PhD journey can offer.

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Introduction

Since its inception in the Spring Semester of 2015, the program has successfully enrolled ten cohorts of students. Approximately 35 students have already defended their theses on a wide range of critical topics such as mental health, digital health, medical humanitarian action, international health regulation, one health, health geography, epidemiology, and healthcare-associated infections. The program has currently more than 60 dedicated students who are actively engaged in their PhD training. Many of these students are professionals working in esteemed international health organizations and non-governmental organizations, including WHO, UNAIDS, USAIDS, UNOPS, Global Fund, GAVI, ICRC, UNICEF, and MSF. Nearly half of the students are based outside of Europe, illustrating the program's global reach and diverse international representation.

The program is tailored to meet the needs of aspiring researchers, lecturers, and mid-career professionals who seek to advance their research skills while remaining actively involved in their respective fields. By offering an environment for growth and development, the program supports individuals in furthering their research expertise and making a lasting impact on global health.

Program Vision & Goals

The PhD program in Global Health is designed to empower national and international health professionals by enhancing their research skills and academic abilities. With a specific focus on implementation research, the program equips students with the necessary tools to apply research findings effectively in real-world settings.

Ideal for health professionals at all career levels, including researchers, practitioners, and aspiring academics, the program offers a tailored curriculum that broadens and deepens their understanding of global health. Through the exploration of global health approaches through courses, workshops and academic work, students gain valuable insights and perspectives that can be applied in diverse health contexts worldwide.

We aim to train working professionals, embedded in organizations across the globe, to become independent researchers capable of designing and conducting research projects. We strive to build strong connections between organizations and academic institutes, fostering collaboration to ensure research has a meaningful impact on field projects.

The program prepares students to conduct independent research within their respective organizations, providing them with mentorship and guidance from academic supervisors. Our ultimate goal is to develop proficient researchers who can work autonomously in interdisciplinary teams. By focusing on implementation research, we aim to address real-world problems from both practical and academic perspectives.

Applying to the Doctoral Program

Applicant profile

The PhD program is aimed at working professionals residing in Switzerland or abroad with the potential of becoming global health leaders, academics and researchers. PhD candidates for this program come from various health professional levels such as directors, mid-career managers and leaders in governmental/non-governmental health agencies, program officers, and other mid-level or senior managers working for foundations. The program also aims to include other public health professionals such as entrepreneurs and individuals working in non-traditional settings.

The program does not provide a scholarship or any other funding to its enrolled PhD students. Applicants should therefore ensure, and be able to demonstrate, that they are financially fully covered for the duration of the PhD.

Types of PhD applicants

PhD applicant with employee status

PhD applicants who are employed by the University of Geneva (UNIGE) or the Geneva University Hospitals (HUG) are referred to as PhD candidates with employee status. For information regarding employment terms and conditions, professional development opportunities, practical issues, human resources, and contact details, you can access the UNIGE intranet.

Employee pursuing a doctorate

If you are working at the University of Geneva (UNIGE) or the University Hospital Geneva (HUG) in a role other than that of a PhD candidate and have made arrangements to pursue a doctorate while employed, you are considered an employee pursuing a doctorate. In such cases, it is important to have discussions and come to agreements with your manager regarding the allocation of your working hours for doctoral research. This will ensure clarity and enable proper planning for balancing your job responsibilities and doctoral studies.

PhD applicant with payed position at external organization or entity

Externally funded PhD applicants have the opportunity to dedicate some of their employer's time (which could be a government, company, or research institute) to work on their doctoral research. In many cases, they are granted a partial exemption from their regular work duties to allow for focused research. While their salaries are paid by their employers, these candidates conduct their doctoral research under the supervision of a designated supervisor from the University of Geneva (UNIGE). They are fully enrolled at University of Geneva as doctoral students.

PhD applicant with a scholarship

Prospective PhD applicants who are interested in pursuing a PhD with the support of a scholarship, but without formal employment, are encouraged to reach out to the PhD coordination office, specifically Dr. Nathalie Bot (nathalie.bot@unige.ch) and Dr. Fleur Hierink

(fleur.hierink@unige.ch). In many cases, external scholarship providers require official confirmation of acceptance into a PhD program before approving a scholarship application.

Admission requirements

Admission to the PhD program in Global Health is determined by the Dean of the Faculty of Medicine, based on the evaluation of the candidate's application by the Steering Committee. Once accepted into the program, it is essential for each student to complete the official enrollment process at the University of Geneva in order to secure their position. The official enrollment process is a required step for all accepted students and involves completing the necessary paperwork and fulfilling any additional requirements set by the university. This process ensures that students are officially registered as PhD candidates at the University of Geneva.

The application deadline for the PhD program is annually on April 1st. To apply, each candidate is required to submit a comprehensive project proposal for their intended PhD study.

A strong project proposal should encompass several key elements. Firstly, it should provide a clear rationale for the study, outlining the significance and relevance of the chosen topic and the associated research questions. Secondly, it should present a well-defined research methodology that will be employed to investigate the research question. Thirdly, the proposal should outline the expected publications that will result from the study. Additionally, it should include a realistic timeframe and research plan for the completion of the study. Lastly, the proposal should address the financial aspect, indicating how the study will be financially supported. Prospective applicants are encouraged to include relevant details regarding the data gathering process, partnerships with research institutes and organizations, and any other pertinent information that strengthens the overall research plan.

Prospective applicants are advised to ensure that they meet the following criteria before applying to the PhD program in Global Health:

- Hold a Master's degree that is equivalent to at least 90 ECTS credits from a Swiss University or a recognized foreign university. In certain cases, degrees from Swiss High Schools (Haute Ecole Suisse) or other degrees accepted by the Dean of the UNIGE Faculty of Medicine may be considered.

- Demonstrate significant professional work experience in the field of global health, preferably spanning several years. While meeting the academic criteria (i.e. master’s degree) is expected, significant professional work experience is highly valued.

- Must be employed or have secured funding to cover all associated study costs, including tuition fees, research work, accommodation, and travel expenses.

- Be fluent in English, as the language of instruction and communication in the program is English.

- Obtain official recognition and support from the current employer to undertake the doctoral study alongside their professional commitments.

- Ideally, have published scientific articles as either a first author or co-author, demonstrating an ability to contribute to the field of research.

Checklist of documents required for the application:

Mandatory Documents:

- Letter of Motivation
- Curriculum Vitae
- Project Proposal (4-6 pages)
- Master's degree equivalent to at least 90 ECTS (European Credit Transfer and Accumulation System). If the credits are not expressed in ECTS, provide a letter from your university indicating the equivalent ECTS credits.
- Publications List: Having at least one publication as a first author will be highly regarded during the evaluation process.
- Written letter of support from the employer, confirming employment and support for the doctoral study.
- Evidence of financial stability

Optional Documents:

- Support letter from an identified supervisor or co-supervisor, which can strengthen your application.
- Transcripts of grades obtained in epidemiology or statistics (if applicable).

Evaluation

Once you submit your application, the PhD coordination team will carefully review the completeness of your files. Only fully complete and admissible applications will be forwarded to the Steering Committee for evaluation. The Steering Committee will thoroughly assess all applications and identify the most promising applications.

By the end of July, all applicants will receive notification regarding the outcome of their application. If your application is successful and selected, your files will be forwarded to the Dean's Office of the Faculty of Medicine. The approval for admission into the PhD program will be granted by the Dean's Office, following the advice and recommendations of the Steering Committee. Once accepted into the program, it is essential for each student to complete the official enrollment process at the University of Geneva.

Prospective PhD students can expect to receive the final admission decision no later than mid-September. This timeline ensures ample time to finalize the necessary arrangements before commencing the PhD program.

Starting the Doctoral Program

Congratulations on your successful selection for the Global Health PhD program at the University of Geneva! We are happy to have you join the program and embark on your research journey. Now that you have been selected, let's walk you through the necessary steps to enroll at the University of Geneva and gain access to the university's valuable resources, including email accounts and other key facilities.

Registration at UNIGE

Upon acceptance into the PhD program at the University of Geneva, the PhD candidate is responsible for initiating the enrolment procedures. These procedures consist of three crucial steps that must be meticulously followed to ensure a successful enrolment at the university.

Step one: Online enrolment

a) **Obtain an access code to ORISIS:**
To begin the enrolment process, you are required to register online on ORISIS, accessible through this link: https://wwwo.unige.ch/ORISIS_USERS/registration

b) **Proceed to the online application:**
After completing your ORISIS registration, an access code will be sent to you via email. With this code, you can proceed to the online application and access the list of all required documents for enrolment.

c) **Pay the CHF 65.- fee:**
Upon completing the application process, you will need to make a payment of CHF 65.-. Please note that only Credit Cards are accepted for this payment.

Step two: Assembling and sending the enrolment file

a) To complete your enrolment, you must assemble your enrolment file, including all the required documents, and mail it to the registrar's office in Geneva. The address can be found at the following link: https://www.unige.ch/immatriculations/en/conditions

b) Upon the registrar's office receiving your package and verifying that all necessary documents are provided, they will send you an email containing a letter of attestation (in French). This letter will include your student number and will request that you visit the registrar's office in person to finalize the registration process on your next visit to Geneva.

Step Three: Finalizing the enrolment

When you visit the registrar's office in Geneva in person, kindly ensure that you have the following documents to complete the enrolment process:

- The letter of acceptance into the doctoral program signed by the Dean
- The original copies of the documents from your application file
- A valid form of identification (ID)

During this visit, you will be provided with a student card, an email address, and a payment slip for CHF 435.- (the rest of your first semester fees), which can be paid at any Swiss post office. You will also receive your ISIS number and password.

For detailed enrolment procedures, please refer to the following link:
https://www.unige.ch/immatriculations/en/conditions

Global Health Doctoral Program in Geneva

The Global Health PhD program at the University of Geneva has a distinctive approach compared to traditional programs. It is specifically designed for experts and professionals who pursue a PhD alongside their existing positions at international organizations. Typically, self-funded, the program integrates with ongoing initiatives within these organizations worldwide.

The PhD research focuses on practical and implementable studies in the realm of global health. While main supervisors are based at the University of Geneva, co-supervisors within the organizations or in the students' respective countries often provide additional support. Throughout the program, it is mandatory for all PhD students to earn a total of 18 ECTS (European Credit Transfer and Accumulation System).

Four of these ECTS credits are obtained through the annual Spring School in Global Health, a program organized by the PhD program itself. The remaining credits are gained from other ECTS-accredited courses, which require approval from the main supervisor. Additionally, up to 4 ECTS credits can be earned through approved Massive Online Open Courses (MOOCs), as determined by the supervisor and the PhD coordination team. Students have the opportunity to register with the Swiss School of Public Health (SSPH+), an exceptional platform that offers a wide range of courses. For more detailed information about SSPH+ and its offerings, please refer to section provided at page 23.

PhD students are required to **publish two scientific articles** during their doctoral studies. These articles must be published (or fully accepted) in peer-reviewed scientific journals, with the student as the first author and the main supervisor as a co-author.

This flexible framework accommodates professionals, ensures a practical research focus, and provides opportunities for continuous learning and development throughout the program. The handbook will delve into further details to guide you comprehensively.

The PhD program, which can be completed in a minimum of three and a maximum of five years, is structured into two main components: course requirements and research requirements. During the first two years of the program, students are expected to begin fulfilling the required course credits, alongside making progress on their research project which they will present during the predoctoral presentations, typically within three semesters of starting the program. The subsequent second and third years should be dedicated to focused research work, preparing the PhD thesis and completion of the required courses. If necessary, students have the option to extend their studies into a fourth and fifth year.

Duration

The program has a minimum duration of 6 academic semesters, equivalent to approximately 3 years, and a maximum duration of 10 academic semesters, approximately 5 years. However, it is possible to request exemptions from the Dean of the Faculty. It's important to note that the extension period granted to complete the thesis cannot exceed two additional academic semesters.

Program cost

When evaluating the expenses associated with pursuing a PhD in Global Health, it is crucial to consider the 4 main types of costs: university fees, course fees, and travel and accommodation expenses and costs related to research.

At the University of Geneva, tuition fees amount to 500 CHF for the first and last semesters, and 65 CHF for the remaining semesters.

Additionally, there are supplementary tuition fees for specific SSPH+ courses. Students are responsible for the entirety of their expenses, including university matriculation fees and all fees related to their stay in Switzerland.

Let's break down each cost:

1. **University fees**, also known as matriculation fees, are the initial expense. The first semester incurs a fee of 500 CHF, and subsequent semesters have a fee of 65 CHF each. The final semester of the thesis requires an additional fee of 500 CHF. For instance, if your thesis takes three years to complete, you can anticipate paying 500 CHF + 65 CHF for the first year, 65 CHF * 2 for the second year, and 65 CHF + 500 CHF for the last year.

2. The second expense is associated with the **courses** taken in Switzerland. Students are required to complete courses totaling 18 ECTS. Among these, the spring school of global health carries a value of 2 ECTS and costs approximately 700 CHF. This course needs to be undertaken twice during the thesis. The remaining 14 ECTS can be selected from the range of SSPH+ inter-university graduate campus courses, with fees varying based on the course and SSPH+ membership.

3. The third expense considers **travel and accommodation costs** should be accounted for, as they can vary considerably based on the location and duration of your thesis. It is crucial to allocate sufficient funds in your budget to cover all expenses associated with the pursuit of your thesis in Switzerland.

4. Lastly, there are costs related to **research**, such as data gathering or publication fees. For more information on opportunities for scholarships or financial support please read the information below or visit the university website.

Financial support: funding opportunities

There are several avenues available to secure additional funding in order to cover the costs of a PhD program. Consider the following options:

- **Swiss National Science Foundation (SNSF):** The SNSF offers various funding schemes, including mobility funds for international exchanges during the PhD, or financial support that can cover parts or the entirety of the PhD trajectory. Detailed information about these opportunities can be found on the university's website and the website of the SNSF.
- **Foundations and Small Funding Opportunities:** Postgraduate students with promising research project proposals often have the option to apply for financial assistance from foundations and other funding sources. It is advisable to explore foundations that specialize in supporting research within your specific field.
- **Funding Schemes Outside Switzerland:** Many countries have their own science and education funds aimed at encouraging young researchers to pursue studies abroad. These funds offer potential financial support for international PhD programs.

For more comprehensive details and specific eligibility criteria for each funding option, you can find further information online.

Please note that availability and criteria may vary, so it's essential to explore each funding opportunity thoroughly to determine the best fit for your circumstances.

Minimal thesis requirements

In summary, the evaluation of the thesis work includes the following components:

1. **Acquisition of 18 ECTS:** As part of the evaluation process, it is required to obtain a total of 18 ECTS credits. This includes earning 4 ECTS credits in total through participating twice in the Spring School in Global Health.

2. **Pre-doctoral thesis**: The predoctoral thesis report and oral presentation serves as a significant milestone before the completion of the doctoral thesis. During this event, the doctoral student presents their thesis project to the Steering Committee, with at least one member of the student's Doctoral Committee in attendance.

3. **Final exam:** The candidate's thesis manuscript serves as the foundation for a final exam, which assesses the PhD student's ability to effectively communicate their technical research knowledge in a clear and understandable manner. The exam consists of a twenty-minute lecture for a master's level audience, during which a part of the jury is present, followed by questions from the jury.

4. **Thesis manuscript:** The thesis manuscript should consist of a minimum of two accepted publications that have been written as a part of the PhD study. These articles must be published (or fully accepted) in peer-reviewed scientific journals, with the student as the first author and the main supervisor as a co-author. These publications demonstrate the candidate's ability to contribute to the field of study.

5. **Public defense:** A critical component of the evaluation is a successful public defense of the thesis. The candidate presents their work in front of a thesis jury, who assess the quality, significance, and contribution of the research.

Regular meetings with the main supervisor and co-supervisor are essential throughout this entire process. These meetings provide an opportunity for the supervisor to guide and mentor the student through the necessary steps, while also allowing the student to update the supervisor on their progress and seek support when needed. Effective communication with the supervisor is a fundamental element for successful thesis work.

Earning doctoral degree

A « *Doctorate in Biomedical Sciences, Global Health* track » is delivered by the Faculty of Medicine upon successful completion of the doctoral program examinations and acceptance of the thesis manuscript.

Governance Structure

Full responsibility for the academic conduct, standards, and requirements of the doctoral program rests with the Faculty of Medicine of the University of Geneva, through its duly appointed and elected officers and representatives, in accordance with internal guidelines and university policies.

Figure 1 – Organogram of the governance structure of the PhD.

Program Director

The Director of the PhD program, Prof. Nicolas Ray, serves as the chair of the Steering Committee and holds responsibility for overseeing both academic and administrative matters within the program. This includes the administration of academic conduct, enforcing standards, and ensuring compliance with program requirements. The Director plays a crucial role in various aspects, such as recommending admissions, managing financial support, facilitating appropriate advisor-student matches, approving committee chairs and members, and providing guidance to these committees regarding policy interpretation and requirements. Additionally, the Director reviews and makes decisions on all petitions in alignment with the regulations and guidelines of the Medical Faculty of the University of Geneva. Furthermore, the Director fulfills any additional administrative duties and responsibilities assigned by the Dean of the Faculty of Medicine.

Steering Committee

The Director of the PhD program in Global Health serves as the chair of the Steering Committee, which operates as an advisory board. The committee plays a crucial role in recommending and providing advice to the Dean of the Faculty of Medicine on all matters concerning the PhD program. Its responsibilities include setting program objectives and ensuring the successful progression of each student's projects. The Steering Committee acts as a guiding force to ensure the effective implementation and ongoing development of the program. The permanent members are:

Prof. Nicolas Ray (Chair)
Head of Division of Human, Animal, and Environmental Health, Institute of Global Health, UNIGE Faculty of Medicine

Prof. Antoine Flahault
Director of the Institute of Global Health, UNIGE Faculty of Medicine

Prof. Olivia Keiser
Head of division of Infectious Diseases and Mathematical Modelling, Institute of Global Health, UNIGE Faculty of Medicine

Prof. Isabella Eckerle
Geneva Center for Emerging Viral Diseases, UNIGE Faculty of Medicine

Prof. François Chappuis
Head, Tropical and Humanitarian Medicine Division, HUG & Department of Community Health and Medicine, UNIGE Faculty of Medicine

Prof. Karl Blanchet
Director of the Geneva Centre of Humanitarian Studies, Institute of Global Health, UNIGE Faculty of Medicine

Prof. Stéphanie Dagron
Head of division of Global Health Law, Institute of Global Health, UNIGE Faculty of Medicine

Prof. Alexandra Calmy
Vice-Dean for Clinical Research, Head of HIV Consultation, Division of Infectious Diseases, HUG UNIGE Faculty of Medicine

Coordination Team

The Coordination Team, situated at the Institute of Global Health, assumes responsibility for the practical execution of decisions made by the Steering Committee. This team maintains direct communication with applicants and registered students, functioning as a point of contact throughout their involvement in the program. The Coordination Team is comprised of the following members, forming the Coordinating Committee:

- **Prof. Nicolas Ray**
  Program Director, Institute of Global Health
  UNIGE Faculty of Medicine

- **Dr. Nathalie Bot**
  Co-coordinator, Institute of Global Health
  UNIGE Faculty of Medicine

- **Dr. Fleur Hierink**
  Co-coordinator, Institute of Global Health
  UNIGE Faculty of Medicine

- **Mrs Sonia Mondo Brouze**
  Administrative coordinator, Institute of Global Health
  UNIGE Faculty of Medicine

Dean’s office

The Dean's Office at the Faculty of Medicine is the highest authority responsible for overseeing the PhD program. It plays a crucial role in maintaining the program's smooth operation and upholding academic standards. The Dean's Office is involved in various aspects, including approving regulatory changes and managing extensions, mandatory removals, and changes of supervisors.

On the program level, any modifications to the regulatory framework or the steering committee require approval from the Dean's Office.

At the student level, the Dean's Office assesses potential extensions, handles mandatory removals from the PhD program, and approves official changes in the doctoral study management, such as a change of supervisor. Additionally, a representative from the Dean's Office must be present during each final exam and public defense to ensure proper representation and adherence to academic standards. The composition of the Dean’s Office can be found here: https://www.unige.ch/medecine/en/faculty/decanat/

Supervision

The supervisor

The main supervisor must be a **Professor at the Faculty of Medicine at UNIGE.** It's important to note that the term "main supervisor" or "thesis director" doesn't necessarily imply that this person will have the most significant role in day-to-day supervision. Instead, their role is to take on the academic responsibility for the PhD supervision.

Regarding the role and responsibilities, the main supervisor's duties as outlined in the University's doctoral code include:

1. Providing mentorship throughout all stages of the PhD program, from course selection to research program completion.
2. Guiding the student in program planning and ensuring adherence to the planned schedule.
3. Supporting the development of the student's research proposal, advising on the literature review, dissertation writing, and reviewing drafts and final versions of the dissertation and publications.
4. Encouraging and advising on training activities, such as participating in scientific meetings, attending external courses, and conducting fieldwork.
5. Assisting in fund-seeking endeavors, where applicable.
6. Supporting the student's career development.
7. Creating time to openly and respectfully discuss the student's PhD progress.
8. Being the main person responsible for the PhD student in case of co-supervision.
9. Ensuring that the student is allocated an appropriate amount of time to focus on their thesis and that there is an equitable distribution of their time between assistant-related responsibilities, research, and thesis work.

In particular:

- The main supervisor, together with the PhD student, identifies the need for specific additional courses.
- The main supervisor, along with the PhD student, selects members for the thesis Doctoral Committee (more information on the doctoral committee can be found directly below).
- Before the predoctoral presentation and at the end of the first year, the main supervisor must arrange a progress report meeting with the student and the Doctoral Committee, producing a short-written report to be attached to the student's predoctoral report.
- The main supervisor or a designated member of the Doctoral Committee must attend the predoctoral presentation.
- The main supervisor must validate the student's dissertation and submit it, along with a written report, to the program Steering Committee.

Doctoral committee

The main supervisor, in collaboration with the PhD candidate, is responsible for identifying potential members for the Doctoral Committee. The composition of this committee must be approved by the Steering Committee. The Doctoral Committee typically comprises three to four members, with the main supervisor being a mandatory member. The selection criteria for the committee include:

1. The main supervisor, who should be a Professor and a member of the UNIGE Faculty of Medicine.
2. An expert or co-supervisor, holding a doctoral degree, affiliated with a Swiss or foreign university.
3. An expert, holding a doctoral degree, who is a member of a Swiss or foreign university but not a co-supervisor.
4. Optionally, an additional expert without specific academic background requirements may be designated.

The primary purpose of the Doctoral Committee is to ensure proper doctoral training, evaluate the progress of the research, and provide additional expertise. It also serves as a platform for open communication and potential mediation if needed. Specifically, the committee's role includes:

- Evaluating the student's scientific skills and the progress of the doctoral project, allowing the candidate to benefit from the expertise of at least one external expert.
- Providing a forum for the PhD candidate to express opinions in the absence of the thesis director.
- Allowing the thesis director to provide feedback in the student's absence.
- Providing oral recommendations.

Annual meetings with the Doctoral Committee are expected, and the student should meet with the committee at least once a year. After each meeting, the committee should prepare a concise progress report (maximum two pages) and submit it to the coordination team.

Student

The student bears essential responsibilities to ensure steady progress in their PhD journey, encompassing both coursework and research activities. The student's role commences by initiating enrollment at the university and being proactive in seeking advice when necessary. Throughout the thesis work, the student collaborates with the thesis director to align with jointly set objectives. The student's responsibilities are further outlined in the university's doctoral code.

The student's responsibilities include:

- Engaging in regular discussions with the thesis supervisor(s) regarding the progress, challenges faced, and other pertinent aspects of the work.
- Collaborating with the supervisor to determine the specific focus of the thesis based on achieved results.

- Staying updated about relevant training courses that contribute to meeting the objectives.
- Devoting the necessary effort and dedication to achieve the successful completion of the doctoral thesis.
- Providing regular progress reports on the research to the doctoral committee.
- Upholding ethical standards, including the principle of authenticity in the thesis and respecting the confidentiality of any applicable portions of the work.
- Adhering to the collective rules and norms of the research unit in which they are involved, contributing to a harmonious and supportive environment for all members.
- Meeting the payment deadlines for the semester fees.

In essence, the student plays a central role in driving their PhD progress while maintaining a strong commitment to academic excellence and ethical conduct throughout the research journey.

Supervision Agreement

Starting from PhD cohort 10 (September 2023), a supervision agreement will be required for all students and supervisors. This agreement serves the purpose to formalize essential aspects of collaboration between the student and the supervisor regarding the doctoral project. The PhD coordination team will provide the terms and conditions of the agreement to the PhD student.

The agreement will be binding for both the student and the supervisor throughout the entire duration of the PhD program. Once the student receives the agreement via email, they are expected to share the document with their supervisor for signature. Subsequently, the student must co-sign and date the agreement and return it to the doctoral program coordination team. This process ensures clarity and accountability in the supervisory relationship, promoting a successful and productive doctoral journey.

Guidelines and Regulations

As a PhD candidate, there are several guidelines and regulations that you must adhere to in order to ensure that both the doctoral program and your research align with the university's standards. These guidelines and regulations play a crucial role in maintaining the quality and integrity of the doctoral process and ensuring that your research meets the required academic standards.

Doctoral code

Since May 2022 the University of Geneva has adopted a doctoral code. These university-wide guidelines encompass a comprehensive set of general principles that define the philosophy, framework, and requirements essential for a successful PhD project. Moreover, they establish clear roles and responsibilities for all individuals engaged in doctoral training at the University of Geneva. These guidelines are available here: https://memento.unige.ch/en/rectorat/charte-du-doctorat

Regulatory framework

The regulatory framework of the doctoral program comprehensively details all the official requirements and regulations of the PhD program. The document, written in French, can be accessed through the following link: Regulatory Framework of the PhD Program in Global Health.

International double doctoral degree

While the majority of our students typically pursue single-track PhDs within our program, the University of Geneva does have specific regulations for joint doctorates. These regulations provide guidance on seeking permission for a joint doctorate at UNIGE, along with the conditions that apply to such collaborative doctoral programs. For more detailed information, please refer to the following link: https://memento.unige.ch/en/doc/0327

Ethical clearance before data gathering

All PhD students participating in the Global Health PhD program are bound by the university's ethical rules and regulations, which necessitate adherence to the prescribed guidelines. Any research project that is not medical but involves human participants (e.g., a questionnaire, observations or interviews), that could have an environmental impact (only concerns projects taking place in the field and outside the lab); or whose results could be of military, security or political interest, for example (i.e., research with multiple purposes), need to seek advice from CUREG (University Commission for Ethical Research in Geneva): https://cureg.unige.ch/en/

For research involving human beings (HRA), the relevant ethics commission is the Cantonal Commission for Ethics and Research (CCER). To gain ethical clearance for such research projects, detailed information and procedures can be found on the following webpage: https://www.unige.ch/researchdata/en/collect-organise/ethics-legal-obligations/.

The same counts for animal research carried out abroad. All guidance and information can be found here: https://memento.unige.ch/en/doc/0295

It is essential to acknowledge that ethical clearance may vary based on the country of data gathering. Therefore, it is advisable to consult the ethical guidelines applicable in the country of research and within your respective organization. Ensuring compliance with ethical standards is paramount in upholding the integrity and credibility of your research endeavors.

Others

An overview of additional guidelines that can be helpful, such as procedures for knowledge transfer and international collaboration guidelines can be found here:
https://memento.unige.ch/en/doc

During Your Doctoral Program

Courses

Throughout your doctoral studies you will follow several courses to meet the requirements of the PhD program. These courses are taken in close consideration with your PhD supervisor, so they fit your research journey as best as possible and so that they equip you with the necessary skills and knowledge to perform your research duties.

You have the flexibility to take courses from various universities, including those outside of Switzerland, as long as the universities can provide you with the ECTS equivalence for the courses, and your supervisor approves of the chosen courses.

A valuable resource for courses offered by Swiss universities is the interfaculty campus SSPH+ (Swiss School of Public Health+). More details about SSPH+ will be provided below.

Course and teaching requirements

The PhD program requires the acquisition of a total of **18 ECTS** credits, distributed as follows:

1. Obligatory:
    - 4 ECTS credits obtained from participating in two Spring School of Global Health sessions, hosted by the Faculty of Medicine of the University of Geneva. These sessions are typically conducted in person, but adjustments can be made to a hybrid or online-only format based on specific contexts, such as the COVID-19 pandemic.
2. Elective:
    - 14 ECTS credits can be earned by enrolling in courses offered by "SSPH+ Inter-University Graduate Campus." Doctoral candidates, in consultation with their supervisors, have the flexibility to select courses that align with their specific needs and personal learning objectives. The formats and modalities of these courses can vary, as long as they adhere to quality criteria set by the program director and include a satisfactory formal evaluation. Students are encouraged to consider participating in the Summer School (economics and health policy) and Winter School in Wengen (epidemiology). If the course is not included in the offerings of SSPH+, the student will be required to obtain program approval and seek support from their primary supervisor.

Among these 14 ECTS credits:

- A maximum of 4 ECTS credits may be acquired by completing two MOOCs. The certificates awarded by the MOOC platforms validate the ECTS acquisition.
- Additionally, students have the option to participate in the One Week Medical School, worth 2 ECTS credits, organized in Geneva by the Institute of Global Health. This program is tailored for non-clinicians.

Certificates:
Students are required to send a copy of the original course certificates to the PhD Coordination Team while retaining the originals for their own records. You have the option to send these copies all at once upon completion of the PhD program or send them throughout the program as you acquire the respective certificates.

SSPH+ (Swiss School of Public Health)

We highly recommend PhD students to enroll in the Swiss School of Public Health (SSPH+). SSPH+ offers PhD students the opportunity to join the Inter-university Graduate Campus (IGC). By enrolling in the IGC, students can enhance their academic skills, competencies, career paths, and networks.

SSPH+ is a foundation that brings together the expertise in public health from 12 Swiss universities. It acts as a virtual inter-university faculty, comprising over 250 professors in public health sciences from different regions in Switzerland.

Through this collaborative approach, SSPH+ supports a diverse range of academic activities across universities to meet the needs and interests of PhD students. By tapping into the collective knowledge and resources of its member universities, SSPH+ provides a unique platform for interdisciplinary learning and collaboration in public health research and practice.

Enrolling in the SSPH+ IGC gives PhD students valuable growth opportunities. They can attend courses, workshops, and seasonal schools conducted by national and international experts in the field. Additionally, they can engage in networking activities, connecting with peers and professionals from various backgrounds to enhance their career prospects and foster valuable connections within the public health community.

To be eligible for enrollment in the SSPH+ IGC, candidates must meet the following criteria:

- Their primary supervisor must be an SSPH+ Faculty member.
- They must be officially registered and approved as a PhD candidate at one of the SSPH+ Foundation's partner universities, such as the University of Geneva.

The SSPH+ IGC provides courses and workshops related to public health research, advanced methods, and thematic subjects. Taught by experts, these courses offer high-level training for PhD students while creating networking opportunities. Registered SSPH+ students can attend these courses for free, with a small processing fee of 30 CHF per course. They can also participate in SSPH+ seasonal schools and partner institutions' courses at reduced fees. There are no specific requirements regarding credits or publications, beyond those set by the student's home university. All Swiss TPH PhD candidates are expected to join the SSPH+ IGC.

The management and coordination of the SSPH+ IGC are overseen by Ann Walser, the Graduate Campus Manager located at the University of Fribourg.

For more information, visit www.ssphplus/en/graduate-campus/.

Research requirements

Publishing scientific articles in peer-reviewed journals

PhD students are required to **publish two scientific articles** during their doctoral studies. These articles must be published (or fully accepted) in peer-reviewed scientific journals, with the student as the first author and the main supervisor as a co-author. Please ensure that all published material during your PhD curriculum appropriately credits the University of Geneva, specifically mentioning the University of Geneva among your affiliations.

It's important to note that the research papers should not be viewpoints, commentaries, editorials, or correspondence pieces. However, such publications can be included in the thesis, in addition to the two published research papers.

There are no specific requirements regarding the type of research papers accepted, as long as they are research papers. For example, a systematic review without primary data collection is acceptable, and a non-quantitative analysis, such as an anthropological study with case studies, is also fine if deemed appropriate within the context of the research.

Before submitting these manuscripts, they must be approved by all co-authors. The main supervisor is actively involved in the planning and review process of the article.

Journals, publication costs, UNIGE agreements

When choosing a journal for submission, it is crucial to consider several factors. One important consideration is the publication costs, known as article processing charges (APC). The University of Geneva has established agreements with certain publishers to reduce or fully cover these publication fees. To access the latest list of journals with such agreements, you can visit this link: University of Geneva - Agreements with Publishers. Many journals, that do not have agreements with the university still offer APC waivers or reductions for researchers from low- and middle-income countries.

Moreover, for those articles that have been accepted in a fully open access journal (i.e., gold open access) but that are not under an agreement, the University of Geneva can cover the full publication cost if it does not exceed 2'500.- CHF. Eligibility criteria and guidelines are fund here: https://www.unige.ch/biblio/en/openaccess/get-published/publication-fund/

Furthermore, SSPH+ owns and publishes two independent society journals, namely the International Journal of Public Health and Public Health Reviews. These journals utilize the systems and services provided by Frontiers.

It is essential to have thorough discussions with your supervisor regarding the choice of journal for submission. They can provide valuable guidance and insights. It is also important to discuss financing opportunities for your papers, ensuring clarity on any available financial support or funding options.

Mid-term Evaluation (pre-doctoral thesis and oral thesis presentation)

The predoctoral thesis oral presentation takes place during the Spring School of Global Health, typically occurring in the second year of the program. This presentation serves as a significant milestone before the completion of the doctoral thesis. During this event, the doctoral student presents their thesis project to the Steering Committee, with at least one member of the student's Doctoral Committee in attendance.

It is crucial to give careful consideration to this milestone, as it plays a pivotal role in the finalization of the doctoral thesis. One month prior to the predoctoral thesis presentation, the student is required to submit a 5- to 10-page summary of their project to the Steering Committee. Following the presentation, the Steering Committee provides their recommendations to both the Doctoral Committee and the student.

The pre-doctoral presentation will be evaluated as either a pass or fail. In the event of a fail, the student will be given a second opportunity to present their pre-doctoral thesis. The maximum time window for the second presentation is 1 year, although the steering committee and the PhD coordination team may propose a shorter timeframe to avoid delays in the doctoral program. It is crucial to highlight that failing the pre-doctoral presentation for a second time will lead to termination from the program.

Pre-doctoral report

The pre-doctoral report serves as a summary of the progress achieved in the first 3 semesters of the PhD program. It encompasses an overview of research progress, such as data collection, ethical committee approvals, literature review, and more. Additionally, it highlights the acquisition of ECTS credits and completion of relevant courses. The report should also identify any bottlenecks or challenges encountered. It is anticipated to be 5-10 pages long and should be submitted to the PhD coordination team via email, one month prior to the pre-doctoral presentation. The coordination team will subsequently share the report with the Steering Committee members who will be present during the respective presentations.

The outline for the pre-doctoral summary is as follows:

Title page:

- Name of the PhD student(s)
- Name(s) of the supervisor(s)
- Names of the members of the doctoral committee

Summary of the thesis plan (1-2 pages):

- **Context:** Provide an overview of the research background and its significance.
- **Hypotheses:** Clearly state the hypotheses to be addressed in the research.
- **Original research**: Describe the research activities undertaken to address the hypotheses.
- **Work achieved:** Summarize the progress made so far.
- **Remaining work:** Identify the tasks that still need to be completed.
- **Publication status:** Detail any thesis-related publications, including abstracts, conference contributions, or published papers. Include full manuscripts or published papers in the appendix.

Body of the summary report:

- **Introduction:** Provide contextual elements of your PhD research, including the problem statement and relevant existing knowledge from referenced sources.
- **Papers:** Outline the status of any publications associated with your research. For submitted or published papers, provide the abstract and attach the whole manuscript or published paper in the appendix. For papers that are not yet submitted or published, include an abstract covering background, research question, methodology, main results (if any), and discussion/conclusion. Additionally, indicate the status of the paper, timelines, and expectations for future work. Please ensure that all published material during your PhD curriculum appropriately credits the University of Geneva, specifically mentioning the University of Geneva among your affiliations.
- **Discussion:** At this stage of the doctoral curriculum, a comprehensive discussion may not be expected. However, it may be useful to highlight key points for consideration. Please include references using Endnote or Zotero.

Pre-doctoral presentation

The pre-doctoral presentation takes a maximum of 15 minutes and outlines the progress made in the first two years of the PhD. The student is required to prepare a presentation consisting of a maximum of 15 slides, excluding the title slide. The presentation should include the following slides:

- **Slide 0:** Title slide, including the name of the PhD student, supervisor(s), and doctoral committee.
- **1st slide:** "Short CV" - Highlight the main elements of your resume.
- **2nd slide:** Context - Present the current state of the art, supported by short references (e.g. Anderson R, Nature, 2014).
- **3rd slide:** Research question and main hypotheses.
- **4th-7th slides:** Present your research work (paper 1) and its current status.
- **8th-11th slides:** Present your research work (paper 2) and its current status.
- **12th-13th slides:** Address any bottlenecks or limitations you may be facing, if applicable, and outline your future plans.
- **14th slide:** Conclusion and any personal remarks or acknowledgments.
- **15th slide:** Summarize your status of training activities, including the number of ECTS you have obtained and the courses from which you earned them.

PhD coordination support

The PhD coordination team, located at the Institute of Global Health in Campus Biotech, Geneva, plays a crucial role in providing support, guidance, advice, administrative assistance, and mentoring throughout your PhD journey. They serve as your primary contact for any administrative inquiries or concerns related to your PhD program. Additionally, they organize the annual spring school in global health and aim to arrange additional workshops and courses

based on student feedback. Currently, the PhD coordination team comprises Dr. Nathalie Bot and Dr. Fleur Hierink.

Writing room

The Writing Room offers students the opportunity to engage in focused writing sessions alongside their peers and a designated member of the coordination team. These sessions, which typically last for two to three hours, are specifically dedicated to collaborative writing support.

To facilitate these sessions, the coordination team organizes a hybrid space where students can freely join and dedicate several hours to their writing tasks. The goal is to create an environment that encourages productivity and fosters a sense of shared commitment to the writing process.

Open House sessions

Open House sessions are monthly informal meetings organized for each cohort, typically on Wednesdays. These sessions, which usually last for an hour, are conducted online but may also have a hybrid format. The primary purpose of Open House sessions is to provide an accessible and inclusive platform for students to ask any questions, meet amongst each other or share ideas related to their PhD journey.

During these sessions, students have the opportunity to interact with their peers and engage in discussions. While students can chat amongst themselves, the coordinator also checks in with the students and addresses any PhD-related matters. This may include practical or regulatory queries regarding courses, PhD exams, pre-doctoral presentations, as well as sharing ideas or expressing desires for additional meetings, writing support, or courses. The content and topics covered during Open House sessions vary depending on the specific needs and interests of the students.

Initially, separate cohort meetings are organized; however, as cohorts progress past their first or second year, the older cohorts may be merged together since their phases and questions become more similar.

The open House sessions are scheduled three months in advance. Additionally, a reminder is sent on the day of the session to all participants. If needed, a brief summary of the meeting is shared with the participants, providing necessary information to keep everyone informed.

Open House sessions provide a supportive and interactive environment where students can seek guidance, share experiences, and connect with their peers. It is an opportunity to foster a sense of community and ensure that students receive the assistance they need throughout their PhD journey.

Moodle

Moodle is an online educational platform specifically designed to support the creation, management, and monitoring of courses. Its primary objective is to facilitate online education and learning activities. Additionally, the doctoral program in Global Health has its dedicated

Moodle page, which is consistently updated with all the essential information related to the PhD program. This includes documentation, upcoming open house session dates, recommended MOOCs completed by fellow students, as well as other important announcements.

To access the doctoral program's Moodle page, you can create a Moodle account using your university credentials and search for the course in the catalogue using the search term "Doctoral Program in Global Health". This will allow you to access all the relevant resources and materials provided within the platform.

Health and Well-being

A PhD journey can sometimes present challenges which are demanding, unpredictable, and overwhelming for students. It is essential to recognize the potential toll it can have on one's well-being. Prioritizing a healthy work-life balance and taking care of your mental health is key.

To address this concern, the University of Geneva has launched an initiative called #MyMindMyPriority. This program aims to raise awareness among students about the importance of mental health and provides them with various resources to achieve a balanced lifestyle.

Through the #MyMindMyPriority campaign, students at the University of Geneva gain access to a range of support services and resources. For all information regarding the university's resources please see: University of Geneva – My Mind My Priority.

Coordination team support

The PhD coordination team is here to support you throughout your doctoral program. They serve as a bridge between students and supervisors, offering guidance and assistance in a confidential and understanding manner. If you have any questions or need help, they can provide answers or direct you to the right university resources. You can always reach Dr. Nathalie Bot (nathalie.bot@unige.ch) or Dr. Fleur Hierink (fleur.hierink@unige.ch) by e-mail.

Psychologist and psychological hotline

The University of Geneva provides valuable psychological support services to students when needed. A dedicated team of psychologists is available to schedule sessions at a reduced fee to make it more accessible and affordable for students.

To schedule appointments, you can easily reach out to them through email (psychologique@unige.ch) or phone (+41 22 379 74 41). They will assist you in booking a session and provide the necessary guidance and support.

In the case of a psychological emergency, the university has a hotline available at different hours and languages. For detailed information on the hotline and its availability, please visit: University of Geneva - Psychological Hotline for Students.

The university understands the importance of mental well-being and has taken proactive measures to ensure that students have access to the necessary support and resources during their academic journey.

Mediation

If you find yourself in need of mediation during your PhD journey, the university provides a dedicated mediation service designed to offer counseling and assistance in resolving conflict situations that may arise between individuals involved in the PhD process. The mediation service aims to facilitate open communication, understanding, and cooperation to reach mutually agreeable solutions. For more information or to access the mediation service, please visit: University of Geneva Mediation Service.

Confidential Advisor

At the University of Geneva, confidential counselors are available to provide support and guidance in challenging situations related to conflicts with staff members, psychological or sexual harassment, sexist, homophobic, or racist comments, verbal and physical violence, as well as social, psychological, or medical problems. They offer a safe space to discuss and address these concerns. To access detailed information and contact details for the confidential counselors, please visit: University of Geneva Confidential Counseling Services.

Sports

The UNIGE Sports Department is committed to offering students and staff a wide range of activities that are both fun and beneficial for the body and mind. Engaging in sports not only provides relaxation and focus but also helps develop valuable skills that can be applied in daily life, academics, and professional settings. Students and staff can engage in varying sports activities at a reduced rate. Registration usually starts before each new semester and sometimes multiple day workshop or courses are offered. Registration typically opens prior to each new semester, with occasional multiple-day workshops and courses being offered. For further information and to explore all available sports courses, please visit the following website: UNIGE Sports Department.

Networks and support for PhD Candidates

PhD students have access to a variety of resources specifically designed to help and support them throughout their doctoral program, focusing on developing crucial skills such as academic writing, science communication, networking, and more. These resources within the university aim to assist PhD students in acquiring these essential skills. In addition to these resources, the university organizes group workshops covering various topics relevant to the essential skills needed on the academic journey. These workshops are conducted in both French and English, offering participants a platform to share their experiences and perspectives while benefiting from the diverse backgrounds and disciplinary traditions represented among the attendees. Moreover, the university is responsive to specific requests and can organize workshops tailored to the unique needs of PhD students. You can find information here: https://www.unige.ch/dife/en/teaching-learning/doctorates#toc0

Graduate Campus

Graduate Campus is a platform aimed at supporting doctoral and postdoctoral students by providing comprehensive information and resources. It facilitates the settlement of students into university life, offers details on administrative steps, informs about housing options, and gathers necessary information in one place. The platform also fosters a community of doctoral students, offers workshops to develop cross-disciplinary skills, and increases the visibility of PhD programs. You can also register for the newsletter to keep yourself informed about the upcoming workshops. For all information regarding the graduate campus and its workshops, please visit: https://www.unige.ch/doctorat/doctorat/graduatecampus/

Ethical Considerations and Research Regulations

The Research and Grants Office (RGO) at the University of Geneva is dedicated to providing conceptual, procedural, and administrative support to researchers at UNIGE. They strive to inform the research community about new opportunities and updated procedures, assist in developing research programs and partnerships, enhance the competitiveness of grant applications through administrative support, manage awarded funds, and represent UNIGE researchers in institutional working groups and funding agencies. For more information please check: https://www.unige.ch/recherche/mission_presentation_en

Consulting Service in Statistics

In case you need statistical support during your PhD, we encourage you to take advantage of the services provided by the Research Center for Statistics. The center offers a range of (free) resources that can greatly assist you in navigating the statistical aspects of your research journey.

The Research Center for Statistics is dedicated to promoting and enhancing good statistical practices and offers a consulting service, available to all faculty members and students of the University of Geneva. More information can be found here:
https://www.unige.ch/gsem/en/archives-centers/consulting-service-in-statistics/

Completing Your Doctoral Program

After successfully completing and having at least two scientific articles accepted or published, it is time to conclude your PhD program. In this section of the handbook, we outline the essential steps to finalize your PhD journey.

These steps include:

1. **Writing and finalizing your PhD manuscript:** Start by composing your PhD manuscript and seek feedback from your main supervisor. Once your supervisor approves the manuscript and believes you are prepared for the next phase, you can move forward.

2. **Final exam:** The final exam is a crucial milestone in obtaining your PhD. It involves a lecture-style presentation, as determined by your supervisor, where you present one of the methodology topics covered in your PhD at a master's level to your PhD jury. This exam serves as the first official step towards acquiring your PhD.

3. **Public PhD defense:** After successfully completing the final exam, you are ready for your public PhD defense. This defense entails presenting and defending your research findings and conclusions to the academic community. It is a significant event, marking the culmination of your research journey.

Please refer to the figure on the next page for a summarized overview of the necessary steps and responsibilities of each individual involved in the process.

	Doctoral student	Supervisor(s)	Thesis jury	Thesis jury president	PhD coordination
PhD manuscript submission					
Writing of PhD manuscript and sharing with supervisor					
Approving that the thesis manuscript is of sufficient quality and completeness to initiate the steps towards thesis defense. Check for potential plagiarism					
Forming the thesis jury					
Compose director's report (contains a proposed jury composition) on the PhD manuscript					
Send director's report along with thesis manuscript to the PhD coordination team who transfers it to the Dean's office					
Upon receival of jury approval by the Dean the supervisor shares the PhD manuscript with the thesis jury members and copies the PhD coordination team in the email					
Final exam					
Setting date for final exam once jury composition is validated and share details with PhD coordination team					
Book room or create zoom link for final exam					
Formulating final exam question					
Sharing final exam question with PhD student (7 days before final exam)					
Informing jury and PhD student about exam format					
Preparation of 20-minute didactic presentation					
Evaluating final exam					
PhD defense					
Setting date for thesis defense					
Book room or create zoom link for PhD defense					
Evaluation of PhD manuscript and write evaluation report					
Share evaluation report with jury president					
Gathering all jury reports and give approval for defense					
Preparation of 30-minute presentation					
Chairs the public PhD defense					
Compile and generate the final report. Share the report with all jury members for their review and approval					
Approve jury report					
Share jury report with PhD student and PhD coordination team after jury approval					
After PhD defense					
Adminsitrative process of grade and defense finalization					
Incorporate feedback from jury report					
Check final version of the PhD manuscript and gives green light to print it					
Print thesis					
Upload thesis to archive ouvertes					

Figure 2 – Overview of steps and responsibilities per individual in the final steps of the PhD. When multiple individuals are highlighted it's a collaborative process.

Timeline

The doctoral program has a timeframe of a minimum of 6 semesters (approximately 3 years) and a maximum of 10 semesters (approximately 5 years). After the supervisor and PhD student agree on the finalization and completion of the PhD, which includes the articles accepted or published under the PhD project, they aim to find a date for the final exam and the public defense.

The PhD student needs to do the final exam after having submitted the final PhD thesis and before the public defense. One week before the final exam, the PhD student receives the topic for the final exam. There needs to be at least 2 months between the submission of the final PhD thesis and the public PhD defense. Upon receipt of the PhD manuscript, the thesis jury is given a period of 30 days to evaluate and assess it.

The date for the final exam needs to suit the UNIGE members of the thesis jury. The date for the public defense needs to suit all members of the thesis jury, both external and internal.

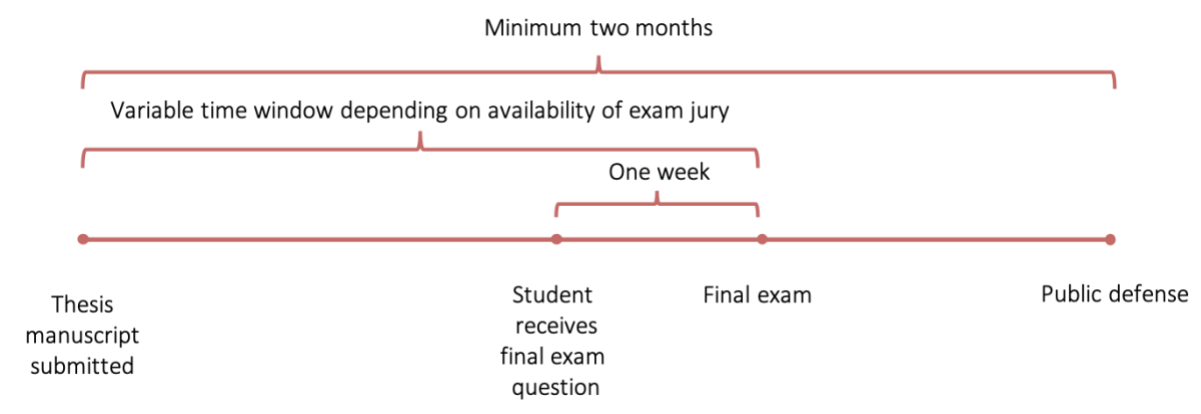

Figure 3 – The timeline for the final phase of the doctoral program consists of three key milestones: the submission of the thesis manuscript, the final exam, and the public defense. It is important to note that the duration between these milestones can vary.

Setting up the thesis jury and composition

The thesis jury consists of a minimum of 4 members, including:

a. The academic supervisor(s) of the doctoral student.
b. A designated member of the Steering Committee, who serves as the president of the jury.
c. A representative from the Dean's office.
d. One or two external experts who hold a doctoral degree.

The formation of the thesis jury occurs once the supervisor is informed of the completion and finalization of the doctoral program and is formed by the supervisor. It is beneficial to establish the jury and determine its composition as early as possible to facilitate the scheduling of a suitable date for all jury members.

Submitting the Thesis

Once the PhD student and supervisor(s) have reached an agreement on the completion of the PhD program, the student is required to submit the final PhD thesis to their supervisor. The supervisor, in turn, shares the manuscript with the thesis jury for evaluation. Furthermore, along with the manuscript, a report from the academic supervisor must be submitted. It is mandatory to submit the complete thesis at least **two months** prior to the scheduled date of the thesis defense. The proposition for the composition of the thesis jury is then presented to the Dean by the main supervisor. After the Dean's validation of the thesis jury composition, the manuscript is distributed to the respective members of the thesis jury for evaluation.

To ensure consistency, the student must adhere to a specific outline provided below.

Format & language

The thesis dissertation serves as a demonstration of the PhD candidate's expertise in managing crucial global health-related projects. The manuscript must be written in English or French (if so, all jury members must be able to read French). If written in English, an abstract of 1 to 2 pages in French should be included. The cover page should be in French. During the initial submission, the manuscript should be in Word document format (A4). Printing of the thesis is only allowed once it has been evaluated for plagiarism issues and has received a successful "imprimatur" status.

Manuscript based on articles:

If the candidate has published two scientific articles in peer-reviewed journals, with the candidate as the first author and the main supervisor as a co-author, the manuscript may follow a specific structure as outlined below. The publications should be incorporated within the manuscript accordingly.

1. Acknowledgments (optional)
2. List of publications, manuscripts in preparation, submitted manuscripts, oral communications produced during the study period which may or may not be directly related to the thesis topic
3. Abstract in English
4. Abstract in French (1-2 pages)
5. Outline
6. General introduction (8-10 pages)
   Must be more elaborate than the introductions in the published articles
7. Articles
   Methodological Contributions (1-2 pages)
   The methods must include a section detailing the role of the candidate in the thesis work (role in protocol elaboration, literature search, data collection and analysis, paper writing)
   Article 1
   Article 2
   …
8. Conclusions and perspectives (5-10 pages)
   Must be more elaborate than the conclusions found in published articles
9. Bibliography (Vancouver format)
10. Annexes (if applicable)

Monograph:
In the case that the candidate has produced a monograph, the structure detailed below must be followed:

1. Acknowledgments (optional)
2. List of publications, manuscripts in preparation, submitted manuscripts, oral communications related to the thesis
3. Abstract in English
4. Abstract in French (1-2 pages)
5. Outline
6. General introduction and research hypothesis
7. Material and methods
   The methods must include a section detailing the role of the candidate in the thesis work (role in protocol elaboration, literature search, data collection and analysis, paper writing)
8. Results
9. Discussion
10. Conclusion and perspective
11. Bibliography
12. Annexes: publications from the candidate, if any

Book chapter:
If the candidate has authored a book chapter as the first author, co-signed by the main supervisor, it can be incorporated into the thesis manuscript. This allows for the inclusion of the book chapter as part of the overall thesis document.

Responsibilities

Student:
- Writes the PhD manuscript.
- Submits the completed PhD manuscript to the supervisor.

Supervisor:
- Takes full responsibility of approving that the thesis manuscript is of sufficient quality and completeness to initiate the steps towards thesis defense. Check for potential plagiarism must have been done by the supervisor.
- Sends the director's report (contains a proposed jury composition) along with the thesis manuscript to the PhD coordination team who transfers it to the Dean's office.
- Awaits approval from Dean's office of jury composition.
- Upon receival of jury approval the supervisor shares the thesis manuscript with the thesis jury members and copies the PhD coordination team in the email. The supervisor should be aware that sharing the thesis manuscript should be done at least 30 days before the public defense date.

Thesis evaluation
Upon receiving the manuscript, the thesis jury is granted a period of 30 days to evaluate it. At the conclusion of this timeframe, the president of the thesis jury is responsible for preparing

an evaluation report **based on the reports of the individual jury members**. The report explicitly indicates whether the candidate has qualified for the thesis defense. The report will be forwarded to the Dean and steering committee by the coordinating team.

If the manuscript does not meet the necessary qualifications for progression, it will be regarded as the candidate's first failure. In the written report, the jury must specify the modifications required to be made by the candidate. It is important to note that a second failure is considered final and conclusive.

Final Exam

The final exam is conducted towards the completion of the doctoral program. It is conducted as a final step to assess the candidate's readiness to obtain their doctoral degree. The final exam is a 20-minute oral presentation and assessment that evaluates the candidate's knowledge, didactic skills, and ability to communicate their research effectively. The final exam needs to be successfully passed (minimum grade of 4 out of 6) to continue preparations towards the public defense.

The Exam Jury

- The Exam Jury is composed of the academic supervisor, a member of the program Steering Committee, and a member from the Dean's office.
- The exam jury consists of the same members as the defense jury, with the exception that the external expert is not included in the exam jury.
- The member of the Steering Committee chairs the exam session.

Final Exam Format

The final exam for the doctoral program involves giving a 20-minute presentation. The supervisor will decide on the topic one week before the exam, giving the student enough time to prepare. It's important to make sure the presentation is understandable to a master's level audience, even if they don't know much about the specific research method or theme. Using clear language, informative slides, and practical examples will help make the topic easier to grasp. Remember to focus solely on delivering a well-prepared lecture on the assigned topic and avoid talking about personal research or achievements, as this presentation is separate from the thesis defense.

The final exam format for the doctoral program includes the following key elements:

Exam Preparation

- The final exam is based on the thesis manuscript.
- The candidate receives the exam question from the supervisor/exam jury one week before the presentation to allow time for preparation.

Oral Presentation

- The final exam takes the form of an oral presentation.
- The candidate is required to make a 20-minutes presentation focusing on one of the methodologies used in their thesis work, as requested by the supervisor/exam jury.
- The presentation should be tailored to a master's level audience, assuming limited familiarity with the methodology or specific theme of the research.
- Emphasis is placed on the candidate's teaching skills and their ability to effectively communicate complex concepts to the audience.

Presentation Requirements

- The presentation should include informative slides that enhance understanding of the chosen topic.
- Use clear and concise language in the presentation, avoiding technical jargon whenever possible.
- Provide practical examples to illustrate concepts and increase accessibility for the audience.
- Ensure the content is visually appealing, visually represented, and organized logically.
- Strictly adhere to the maximum allocated time of 20 minutes.

Focus on Assigned Topic

- The candidate should solely focus on delivering a well-prepared lecture on the assigned topic provided by the supervisor: It is important to refrain from incorporating details about the candidate's research articles or scientific achievements during the presentation. This presentation is separate from the thesis defense.

Final Exam Evaluation Criteria

- The exam is graded using the Swiss grading scale of 1 to 6, where 6 represents excellent performance.
- Criteria considered during the exam evaluation include:
    - Information contained in the presentation:
        - Correctness of the information.
        - Accuracy of descriptions.
        - Relevance of theories and citations.
    - Form/Quality of the PowerPoint presentation:
        - Language quality.
        - Clear and well-structured presentation.
        - Consistent progression of information.
        - Clearly stated learning objectives.
        - Time management (20 minutes maximum)
    - Oral communication and answers to questions:
        - Respect for the presentation duration.
        - Clear explanations.
        - Appropriate pace.
        - Engagement with the audience.

Responsibilities

Supervisor:

- Once the jury composition is validated, the supervisor sets the date for the final exam and communicates it to the PhD coordination team.
- Informs the PhD coordination team whether a room or Zoom link needs to be booked or shares the location details.
- Develops the final exam question that the candidate will address during the presentation.
- Seven days before the final exam, the supervisor communicates the exam question to the PhD student (which can also be done by the PhD coordination team if desired), with the PhD coordination team copied in the communication.

PhD student:

- Prepares a 20-minute didactic presentation focused on the exam topic provided by the supervisor, targeting a Master's level audience (see details above).

PhD coordination team:

- Send final exam question if required by supervisor.
- Sends reminders to the PhD student, supervisor, and final exam jury regarding the final exam.
- Attends the final exam presentation and informs the student of the final grade.
- Provides administrative support for organizing the exam and oversees the process.

Final exam jury:

- Attends the final exam.
- Asks questions after the final exam presentation.
- Evaluates the final exam based on the criteria mentioned above.

Doctoral Thesis and Defense

Once the PhD manuscripts has been successfully submitted, the final exam has been satisfactory, and the PhD defense has been scheduled with an approved thesis jury, the defense takes place.

The thesis defense is allotted a duration of 30 minutes, during which the candidate presents their work. This is followed by an additional 60 minutes dedicated exclusively to discussions with the thesis jury. The thesis defense is a public event, but it should be noted that participation in the discussion by attendees from the public is not permitted during the defense itself.

However, once the defense concludes and the jury president announces its completion, the floor is opened to the public for any questions or comments they may have.

Following the defense, the thesis jury convenes for closed-door deliberations, led by the president of the jury. The jury then determines whether to grant the thesis either with or without

honors, based on their assessment and evaluation of the work. There are three types of honors that can be awarded based on the performance of the candidate: "assez bien" (satisfactory), "bien" (good), and "très bien" (very good).

Preparing for your thesis defense

The thesis defense serves as a significant milestone in your PhD journey, and it is crucial to approach it with thorough preparations. To support you in this important moment, the University of Geneva offers workshops specifically designed to help you adequately prepare. During these workshops, both the form and content of your presentation will be thoroughly addressed. You will receive comprehensive guidance throughout the entire process, providing you with valuable tools and ideas to effectively anticipate and respond to the questions raised by the thesis jury.

Moreover, the workshops create a platform for participants to engage in open discussions, share personal experiences, and exchange diverse perspectives with fellow PhD students from various disciplines.

For more detailed information on these workshops, including dates and registration, please visit the following website: University of Geneva Workshops

Responsibilities

All roles and responsibilities during the finalization of the program are dynamic and require active collaboration and interaction among all individuals involved. To provide a visual representation of each responsibility, please refer to Figure 2, which illustrates the various roles.

Supervisor:

- Ensures effective communication with the thesis jury regarding the defense.
- Determines and communicates the date of the defense to the PhD coordination team.
- Notifies the PhD coordination team if a room or Zoom link needs to be booked, or shares the location details.
- Attends the public PhD defense.
- After the defense, check that any agreed oral and written recommendations from the thesis jury be incorporated in the final version of the thesis.

PhD student:

- Prepares a 30-minute presentation highlighting the work done during the PhD, emphasizing time management.
- Responds to questions posed by all members of the thesis jury.
- Incorporates necessary feedback and oral and written recommendations from jury members into the final PhD manuscript.

PhD coordination team:

- Supports the PhD student and supervisor in organizing the PhD defense if needed, including communication with the jury and reservation of a room or a Zoom link.
- Attends the public PhD defense.

Thesis jury members:

- Evaluate the thesis manuscript and provides individual reports assessing the quality and offering recommendations for the PhD manuscript. This report is shared with the jury president before the defense.
- Prepare questions for the PhD student to answer during the public defense.
- Attend the public defense.
- Deliberate collectively to determine the grade for the PhD defense.

Thesis jury president:

- Collects all reports from jury members and summarizes the recommendations and findings into an "evaluation report" that will be forwarded after the defense to the Dean's office by the coordination team
- Chairs the public PhD defense, leading by announcing the format and welcoming the audience.
- Introduces the jury members.
- Guides the order of questions from the jury members.
- Facilitates the final discussion on the grade of the student.
- Announces the result to the student.
- Upon approval by the jury members, the director sends the evaluation report to the PhD student, copying the PhD coordination team. The PhD student incorporates this feedback into their manuscript.

After obtaining your PhD

After completing your PhD, there are a series of administrative steps that you will need to follow. You will receive detailed information about these steps through email, but in general, they involve the finalization, printing, and archiving of your manuscript in the university's archive ouvertes.

The first step is to finalize your manuscript, ensuring that all necessary revisions and edits have been made according to the feedback and recommendations provided by your thesis jury. This includes incorporating any additional changes or clarifications required. You must receive the green light from your supervisor for this final version.

Once you receive the "Imprimatur" from the Dean's office, you will need to arrange for the printing of your finalized manuscript. The specific guidelines and requirements for printing will be communicated to you, such as the number of copies needed and any specific formatting instructions.

Once your manuscript has been printed, it will be necessary to archive it in the university's archive ouvertes.

Alumni network

UNIGE Alumni is an association for all graduates of the University of Geneva. Established in 2009, our network of thousands of members spans across Geneva, Switzerland, and over 90 other countries. As part of this network, alumni benefit from connections with a diverse group of individuals, job advertisements, and exclusive prices for sports and cultural activities. More information can be found on the Alumni UNIGE website.

Important URLs

These resources cover various aspects of your PhD journey, from enrollment and funding to research support and well-being. Feel free to explore and utilize these URLs to access the specific services you may need during your PhD studies.

1. **Enrollment**
    - General information: Link
    - Obtain an access code to ORISIS: Link
    - Sending your enrollment file: Link
2. **Swiss School of Public Health:** Link
3. **Funding instruments**
    - Research Funding: Link
    - Publication funding:
        - Agreements with publishers: Link
        - Publication Fund: Link
4. **Dean's Office Faculty of Medicine:** Link
5. **Doctoral Code:** Link
6. **Regulatory Framework PhD in Global Health:** Link
7. **International double doctoral degree:** Link
8. **Ethical Clearance for Research**
    - CUREG (University Commission for Ethical Research in Geneva): Link
    - Animal research: Link
    - Others: Link
9. **Health and Well-being**
    - My Mind, My Priority: Link
    - Hotline-Psy Students: Link
10. **Mediation:** Link
11. **Sports:** Link
12. **Doctoral support**: Link
13. **Graduate Campus**: Link
14. **Research and Grants Office:** Link
15. **Consulting service in statistics**: Link
16. **Doctoral workshops (preparation defense, etc.):** Link
17. **Alumni network**: Link